

General Knowledge

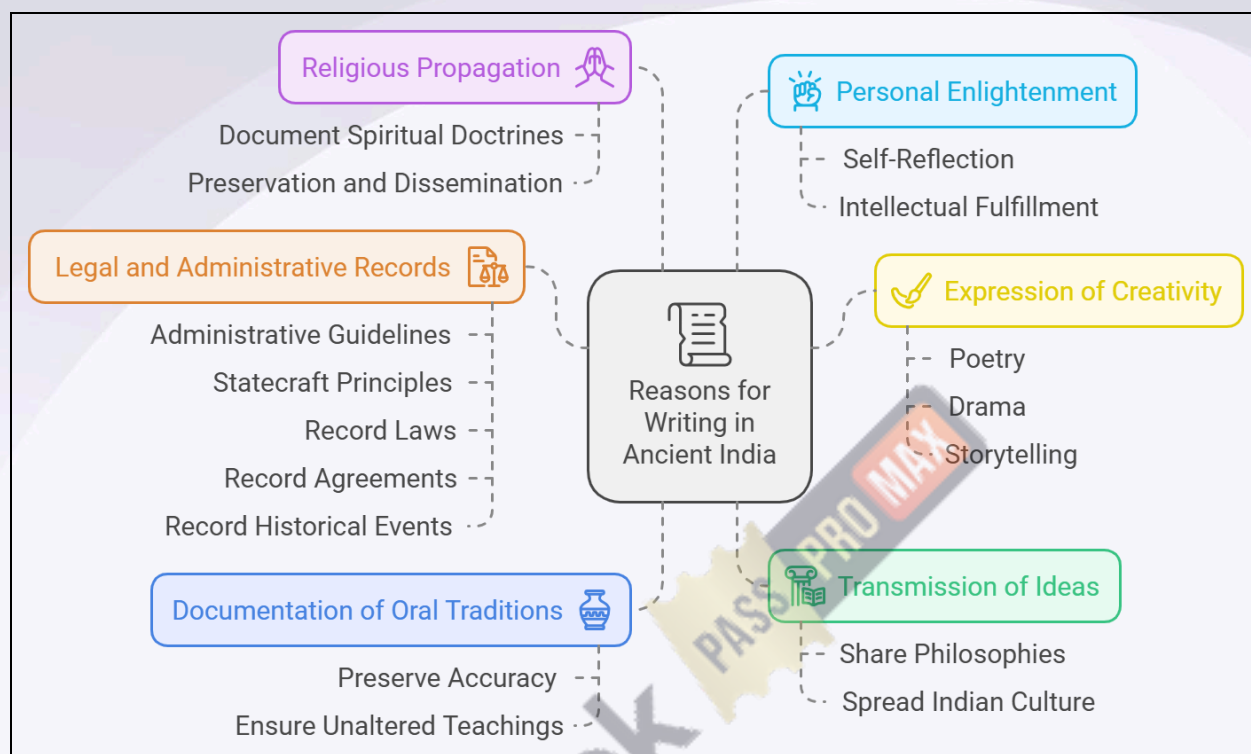
Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Books and Authors of Ancient India



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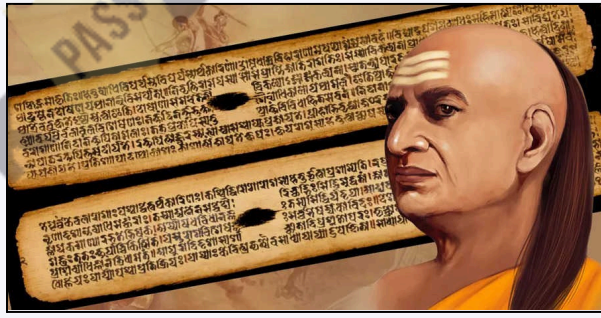


Need and Significance of Books in Ancient India

- **Preservation of Knowledge:**
 - Books in ancient India played a crucial role in preserving **sacred texts, scientific knowledge, and cultural heritage**.
 - They ensured the transmission of knowledge across **generations** in the absence of digital or advanced record-keeping methods.
- **Religious Importance:**
 - Most ancient Indian books, like the **Vedas, Upanishads, and Puranas**, were considered **divine revelations** and were central to religious practices and teachings.
- **Education and Learning:**
 - Books formed the core of **Gurukul education**, where students learned philosophy, astronomy, mathematics, and medicine.

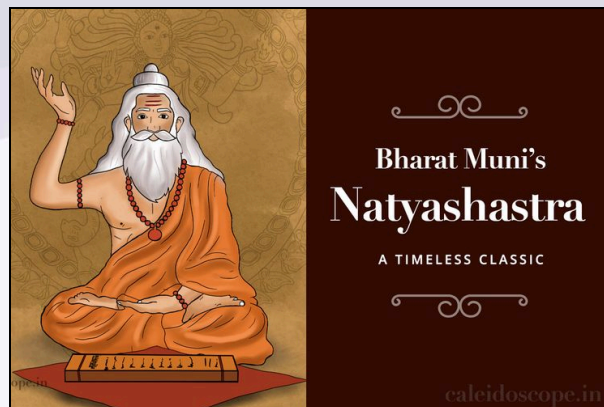
- They were written in **Sanskrit, Prakrit, and regional languages**, making knowledge accessible to different communities.
- **Philosophical and Ethical Guidance:**
 - Texts like the **Bhagavad Gita** and **Manusmriti** provided **ethical, moral, and spiritual guidance**.
 - They were essential for shaping the **values and principles** of society.
- **Scientific and Technical Development:**
 - Books such as **Aryabhatiya** by Aryabhata and **Charaka Samhita** documented advances in **astronomy, mathematics, and medicine**.
 - These works were the foundation of India's contributions to **global science and technology**.

Notable Concepts and Contributions

● Political Literature: Texts like the Arthashastra and Mudrarakshasa focus on governance, strategy, and statecraft.	
● Epics and Mythology: Ramayana and Mahabharata are foundational to Indian culture, exploring themes of dharma (duty) and morality.	

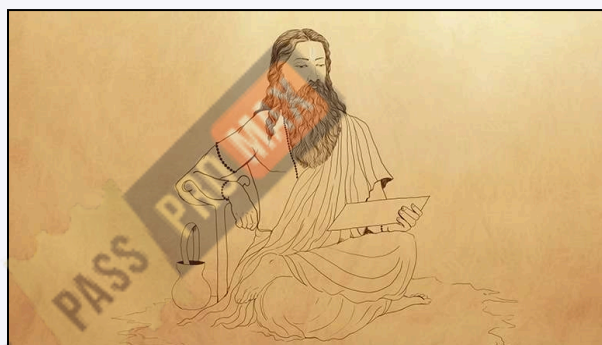
- **Drama and Performance:**

Natyashastra and plays by Kalidasa highlight the significance of arts in ancient India.



- **Ayurveda and Medicine: Charak**

Samhita is a cornerstone of traditional Indian medicine.



- **Fables and Ethics: Panchatantra**

serves to educate through animal stories, encapsulating moral lessons.



Books and Authors: Rig Vedic Period

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Rigveda	Multiple Sages (e.g., Gritsamada, Vishwamitra, Vamadeva)	1500-1200 BCE	Sanskrit	The oldest Vedic text contains 1,028 hymns organized into 10 Mandalas, which are focused on hymns to deities like Agni, Indra, and Soma.
Samaveda	Derived from Rigveda	Around 1200 BCE	Sanskrit	Focused on musical chanting, provides melodies (Saman) for Rigvedic hymns, and is used in sacrificial rituals.
Yajurveda	Multiple Contributors	Around 1200-1000 BCE	Sanskrit	It contains prose and verse for conducting rituals and sacrifices, as well as details on the Yajnas (sacrifices).
Atharvaveda	Multiple Contributors	Around 1000 BCE	Sanskrit	Contains hymns, spells, and incantations related to medicine, health, and daily life; less focused on rituals.
Brahmanas	Priests of the Rigvedic Period	Around 1000 BCE	Sanskrit	Commentaries explaining Vedic rituals and sacrifices; associated with each Veda.
Aranyakas	Composed by Hermits	Around 800 BCE	Sanskrit	Texts meant for meditation and philosophical discussions; "forest texts"

				associated with spiritual seekers.
Upanishads	(Various Sages)	Around 700 BCE	Sanskrit	Philosophical treatises exploring metaphysical concepts; foundational texts for Vedanta philosophy.

Books and Authors: Later Vedic Period

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Shatapatha Brahmana	Sage Yajnavalkya	Around 800-600 BCE	Sanskrit	Associated with the Yajurveda; it discusses rituals, sacrifices, and cosmology; and includes philosophical elements.
Aitareya Brahmana	Mahidasa Aitareya	Around 800 BCE	Sanskrit	Associated with the Rigveda; explains the significance of rituals and sacrifices; and highlights the priestly hierarchy.
Taittiriya Brahmana	Tittiri (School of Yajurveda)	Around 800 BCE	Sanskrit	Provides guidance on Vedic rituals; includes early discussions on Upanishadic philosophy.
Brihadaranyaka Upanishad	Sage Yajnavalkya	Around 700 BCE	Sanskrit	A foundational text of Vedanta philosophy; explores metaphysical concepts like Atman

				(soul) and Brahman (universal soul).
Chandogya Upanishad	Various Sages	Around 700 BCE	Sanskrit	Part of the Sama Veda; focuses on meditation, ethics, and the philosophy of ultimate reality.
Taittiriya Upanishad	(Taittiriya School)	Around 700 BCE	Sanskrit	Discusses education, self-discipline, and metaphysical knowledge; emphasizes Brahman.
Samkhya Sutras	Sage Kapila	Around 600 BCE	Sanskrit	The foundational text for the Samkhya school of philosophy; explores the dualism of Purusha (consciousness) and Prakriti (matter).
Manusmriti	Sage Manu	Around 600 BCE	Sanskrit	A text on Dharma (law and ethics); provides guidelines on social conduct, law, and governance.
Gopatha Brahmana		Around 700 BCE	Sanskrit	Associated with the Atharvaveda; focuses on the rituals and ceremonies of the Atharvavedic tradition.

Buddhist Literature

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Tripitaka (Three Baskets)	Compiled by Buddhist Councils	5th–3rd Century BCE	Pali	Includes Vinaya Pitaka (rules for monastic life), Sutta Pitaka (teachings of Buddha), and Abhidhamma Pitaka (philosophical discourses).
Milinda Panha	Nagasena	Around 100 BCE	Pali	A dialogue between King Milinda (Menander I) and monk Nagasena on Buddhist philosophy and ethical concepts.
Buddhacharita	Ashvaghosha	2nd Century CE	Sanskrit	Epic poem on the life of Buddha; highlights his renunciation, enlightenment, and teachings.
Visuddhimagga	Buddhaghosa	5th Century CE	Pali	A comprehensive manual on meditation and ethics; a key text for Theravada Buddhism.

Mahavamsa	Mahanama Thera	5th Century CE	Pali	Chronicles the history of Buddhism in Sri Lanka, including the arrival of Mahinda and the role of King Ashoka.
Divyavadana		2nd-3rd Century CE	Sanskrit	A collection of legends and stories about the deeds of Buddha and his disciples; emphasizes moral lessons.
Jataka Tales	Compiled by Buddhist Councils	4th Century BCE - 3rd Century CE	Pali	Stories about the previous lives of Buddha; include moral and ethical teachings in narrative form.
Abhidharmakosa	Vasubandhu	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Systematic text on Abhidharma philosophy; explores Buddhist metaphysics and psychology.
Heart Sutra (Prajnaparamita Hridaya Sutra)		Around 1st Century CE	Sanskrit	A Mahayana text summarizing the essence of wisdom and emptiness (Shunyata); is highly influential in Zen Buddhism.

Lankavatara Sutra		4th Century CE	Sanskrit	Discusses the concept of consciousness-only (Vijnanavada) and Buddha-nature; key text in Mahayana Buddhism.
Dhammapada	Compiled by Buddhist Councils	3rd Century BCE	Pali	A collection of Buddha's sayings; emphasizes ethical living, meditation, and wisdom.

Jaina Literature

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Agamas	Mahavira's Teachings (Compiled by Ganadharas)	6th Century BCE	Prakrit	Sacred texts of Jainism; contain Mahavira's sermons and philosophical doctrines.
Kalpasutra	Bhadrabahu	Around 3rd Century BCE	Prakrit	Describes the life of Mahavira and other Tirthankaras; includes Jain monastic rules.
Niryukti	Bhadrabahu	Around 3rd Century BCE	Prakrit	Commentary on Jain scriptures, focusing on explanations and interpretations of ancient texts.

Tattvartha Sutra	Umaswati (Umasvami)	Around 2nd Century CE	Sanskrit	A systematic exposition of Jain philosophy and ethics; universally accepted by both Digambaras and Svetambaras.
Samayasara	Acharya Kundakunda	Around 1st Century CE	Prakrit	Explores the nature of the soul, karma, and liberation; emphasizes self-realization.
Panchastikaya	Acharya Kundakunda	Around 1st Century CE	Prakrit	Discusses the five fundamental substances (Dravyas) in Jain metaphysics, including soul and matter.
Acharanga Sutra	Mahavira's Teachings (Compiled by Ganadharas)	Around 6th Century BCE	Prakrit	Focuses on Jain ethical conduct, especially non-violence (Ahimsa) and self-discipline.
Sthananga Sutra	Mahavira's Teachings (Compiled by Ganadharas)	Around 6th Century BCE	Prakrit	Discusses Jain cosmology, categorization of living beings, and spiritual practices.
Bhagavati Sutra	Mahavira's Teachings (Compiled by Ganadharas)	Around 5th Century BCE	Prakrit	Encyclopedic text covering Jain cosmology, philosophy, and the nature of the soul.

Ratnakaranda Shravakachara	Acharya Samantabhadra	Around 2nd Century CE	Sanskrit	A manual for householders (Shravakas); outlines ethical duties and spiritual practices.
Gommatsara	Acharya Nemichandra	Around 10th Century CE	Prakrit	Comprehensive treatise on Jain metaphysics, karma theory, and liberation.
Niyamasara	Acharya Kundakunda	Around 1st Century CE	Prakrit	Explains ethical and spiritual discipline for attaining liberation.
Prashamarati	Acharya Umaswati	Around 2nd Century CE	Sanskrit	Treatise on inner peace, self-control, and detachment from material desires.

Books and Authors: Magadha Empire

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Arthashastra	Kautilya (Chanakya)	4th Century BCE	Sanskrit	A treatise on statecraft, economics, administration, and military strategy; provides insights into Mauryan governance.

Indica	Megasthenes	Around 300 BCE	Greek	An account of Mauryan administration, society, and culture during Chandragupta Maurya's reign; includes observations of Pataliputra.
Ashokan Edicts	Emperor Ashoka	3rd Century BCE	Prakrit, Brahmi, Kharosthi	Inscriptions on pillars, rocks, and caves; promote Dhamma (moral law), non-violence, and religious tolerance.
Mudrarakshasa	Vishakhadatta	4th Century CE	Sanskrit	A historical drama depicting Chanakya's efforts in establishing Chandragupta Maurya's reign.
Vishnu Purana		4th Century CE	Sanskrit	Provides a historical account of Chandragupta Maurya and the establishment of the Mauryan dynasty.

Books and Authors: Sangam Age

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Tolkappiyam	Tolkappiyar	3rd Century BCE	Tamil	Oldest Tamil grammar text; covers phonetics, grammar, and rhetoric; divided into Ezhuthathikaram, Sollathikaram, and Porulathikaram.
Ettuthogai (Eight Anthologies)	Various Poets	3rd Century BCE–3rd Century CE	Tamil	Collection of 8 anthologies; including Aingurunooru , Purananuru , Ahananuru , Narrinai , Kurunthogai , Paripadal , Kalithogai , and Pathirruppathu .
Purananuru	Various Poets	1st–2nd Century CE	Tamil	Collection of 400 poems; focuses on war, kingship, and heroism; reflects political and social conditions.
Akananuru	Various Poets	1st–2nd Century CE	Tamil	Collection of 400 poems; explores themes of love and personal emotions; part of the Ettuthogai .

Pathupattu (Ten Idylls)	Various Poets	3rd Century BCE–3rd Century CE	Tamil	Collection of 10 long poems; includes Tirumurugarruppadaï , Porunarruppadaï , Malaipadukadam , and others; focuses on love, valor, and devotion.
Manimekalai	Seethalai Sathanar	2nd Century CE	Tamil	Epic focused on Buddhism; a sequel to Silappadikaram ; explores themes of renunciation and morality.
Silappadikaram	Ilango Adigal	2nd Century CE	Tamil	One of the five great Tamil epics; focuses on Kannagi's devotion and the theme of justice.
Civaka Cintamani	Tirutakkadevar	10th Century CE	Tamil	Jain epic highlighting moral virtues and spiritual growth.
Kurunthogai	Various Poets	3rd Century BCE–2nd Century CE	Tamil	Short poems on love and nature; part of the Ettuthogai .
Tirukkural	Thiruvalluvar	1st Century BCE–1st Century CE	Tamil	Philosophical work with 1,330 couplets; focuses on ethics, polity, and love; called the "Tamil Bible."

Paripadal	Various Poets	3rd Century BCE–2nd Century CE	Tamil	Collection of poems on love and devotion; includes references to gods like Vishnu and Murugan.
Maduraikkanchi	Mangudi Maruthanar	2nd Century CE	Tamil	Describes the city of Madurai, its culture, and prosperity; part of the Pathupattu .
Kalithogai	Various Poets	2nd Century CE	Tamil	A collection of 150 poems focusing on love and nature; part of the Ettuthogai .
Pathirruppathu	Various Poets	3rd Century CE	Tamil	A collection of poems praising Chera kings; offers insights into Sangam-era political and social life.
Malaipadukadam	Perunkunrur Perunkaucikanar	3rd Century CE	Tamil	Describes the journey to the hill country; part of the Pathupattu ; reflects nature and heroism.

Books and Authors: Gupta Empire

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Ramayana	Valmiki	Composed much earlier (7th-4th Century BCE, popularized in the Gupta Era)	Sanskrit	Epic detailing the life of Lord Rama; themes of dharma, devotion, and ideal relationships; widely propagated during the Gupta era.
Mahabharata	Ved Vyasa	Composed much earlier (10th-4th Century BCE, refined in Gupta Era)	Sanskrit	Epic narrating the Kurukshetra War; includes the Bhagavad Gita , a spiritual and philosophical guide; widely studied in the Gupta period.
Bhagavad Gita	Ved Vyasa	4th Century BCE (popular in the Gupta Era)	Sanskrit	Philosophical discourse within the Mahabharata; focuses on dharma, yoga, and devotion; central to Gupta-era religious thought.
Mrichchhakatika	Shudraka	5th century CE	Sanskrit	Mrichchhakatika, also known as The Little Clay Cart, is a famous ancient Sanskrit play that is considered one of the greatest works of classical Indian literature.

Aryabhatiya	Aryabhata	499 CE	Sanskrit	Treatise on astronomy and mathematics; introduced zero and trigonometric concepts.
Brahmasphutasiddhanta	Brahmagupta	628 CE	Sanskrit	Discussed advanced concepts in astronomy and mathematics; defined zero and negative numbers.
Kamasutra	Vatsyayana	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Treatise on social relationships, love, and aesthetics; reflects Gupta-era culture and sophistication.
Amarakosha	Amarasimha	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Lexicon provides synonyms and meanings of words; widely used by scholars in Gupta courts.
Panchatantra	Vishnu Sharma	3rd-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Collection of animal fables teaching moral lessons; contributed to storytelling traditions.
Abhijnanasakuntalam	Kalidasa	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Romantic drama narrating the story of King Dushyanta and Shakuntala; highlights Gupta's literary excellence.

Meghaduta	Kalidasa	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	A lyric poem where a Yaksha sends a message to his lover via a cloud; a masterpiece of Sanskrit poetry.
Raghuvamsa	Kalidasa	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Epic poem describing the lineage of King Raghu; reflects Gupta-era ideals of kingship and morality.
Malavikagnimitram	Kalidasa	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Drama showcasing love and court politics; highlights Gupta court culture.
Dashakumaracharita	Dandin	6th Century CE	Sanskrit	Romance prose narrating the adventures of ten princes; represents Gupta storytelling traditions.
Charaka Samhita	Attributed to Charaka	2nd Century BCE (popular in Gupta Era)	Sanskrit	Text on medicine and Ayurveda; focuses on diagnosis and treatment practices.
Sushruta Samhita	Attributed to Sushruta	3rd Century BCE (popular in the Gupta Era)	Sanskrit	Discusses surgery and medical techniques; reflects advancements in health sciences during the Gupta period.

Surya Siddhanta		4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Text on astronomy; discussed planetary motions, eclipses, and time measurement.
Harivamsa	Attributed to Vyasa	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	An appendix to the Mahabharata; narrates the genealogy and deeds of Krishna and the Yadavas.
Mudrarakshasa	Vishakhadatta	4th-5th Century CE	Sanskrit	Historical drama about Chandragupta Maurya's rise to power with Chanakya's help; reflects Gupta's political interests.

Books and Authors: Harshavardhana Empire

Book Name	Author/Composer	Estimated Year	Language	Significant Features
Harshacharita	Banabhatta	7th Century CE	Sanskrit	Biography of Emperor Harsha; provides insights into his life, administration, and cultural achievements.
Kadambari	Banabhatta (completed by his son)	7th Century CE	Sanskrit	Romantic prose narrative; is considered one of the earliest novels in Indian literature.

Nagananda	Harshavardhana	7th Century CE	Sanskrit	A Buddhist drama celebrating the values of compassion and self-sacrifice; based on the Bodhisattva Jataka tales.
Ratnavali	Harshavardhana	7th Century CE	Sanskrit	A romantic drama showcasing courtly life and love; reflects Harsha's literary talent and patronage.
Priyadarsika	Harshavardhana	7th Century CE	Sanskrit	Another romantic drama; highlights themes of love, separation, and reunion in the royal setting.
Si-yu-ki (Record of the Western World)	Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang)	7th Century CE	Chinese	A travelogue documenting Xuanzang's journey to India; provides valuable descriptions of Harsha's empire, including its culture, administration, and Buddhist influence.
Dashakumaracharita	Dandin	7th Century CE	Sanskrit	Prose narrative exploring the adventures of ten princes; highlights the Gupta-Harsha transition in literature.